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Place Coverage: !Kung San, Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia

Section Title(S)

Categories 3 and 4: step-parents, &c; name relatives • Deviations from the rules

Categories 3 and 4: step-parents, &c; name relatives

The third category to which the incest taboo is extended, step-parents, &c., needs no elucidation.

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The fourth category, certain name relatives, should be further described. The name relationship, described in the paper on kin terminology,¹ is connected with a system of naming children. The !Kung have no surnames. A !Kung father invariably names his first-born son or daughter for his parent of the same sex; usually the second-born for the parent of the child's mother; subsequent children for his own sibling or the sibling of the child's mother or the spouses of those siblings. He never names a child for himself or for the child's mother. Because this pattern of naming exists, the !Kung feel that if two non-consanguineous persons have the same name, they are likely to have had consanguineous connexions in the forgotten past, and from this concept the !Kung have developed what we called their name relationship. In a system too complex to summarize here they apply kin terms to persons on the basis of their names.

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The names have passed from family to family, through intermarriage in the region, and from generation to generation, to such an extent that every !Kung

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of the region whom we interrogated on the subject had a kin term for every other !Kung, except for one man who had once met four !Kung from afar for whom he had no terms. This had made him uneasy.

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The !Kung welcome the sense of belonging to an in-group which the name relationship affords them. They welcome also the fact that they know how to behave with people with respect to the avoidances. They fear (*koa*) to make a mistake about joking and sitting, they say, and feel secure in righteousness and propriety when they know what behaviour is correct and conform to it. The kin terms sort out the whole !Kung population of the region for them. They avoid joking with name relatives whose names classify them with kin or affines of the generation of parents, or with offspring or with a sibling of opposite sex or with great-grandparents. They may joke with name relatives whose names classify them with grandparents, a sibling of the same sex, or the spouse. (Cf. Figs. 2 and 3.)

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The incest taboo is extended to name relatives. If ego is forbidden to marry them because of the way their names classify them, he also does not joke with them. But, as we shall see when we consider approved marriages, the system does not maintain perfect consistency between joking and marriage among name relatives, and it does not follow that if ego must not joke he therefore must not marry. The incest taboo is extended specifically to the following name relatives: (1) anyone who has the name of ego's parent or offspring; (2) the parent, offspring or sibling of opposite sex of anyone who has the same name as ego, (3) anyone who has the same name as ego's spouse's parent or his offspring's spouse. #Toma explained that it would 'sound as though' one had married his parent, child, or one of these close affines.

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Deviations from the rules

The !Kung conform strictly to their marriage regulations in the first two categories, kindred and affines. None of the persons whose genealogical records we 344 gathered (about 175) had married lineal kin or collaterals, at least through first cousins. However, informants told about two !Kung men in B.P. who had married their cousins: we could not find out which type of cousins. What was interesting was the attitude of the informants. They said the men should not have done this, but there was no talk of madness or danger or expressions of horror such as we had observed when incest was spoken of at other times. No punishments, social or divine, had been meted out, according to the informants. Some said they thought it was not too bad a thing for a man to do, especially if the woman were a FaSiDa, who is not, they said, so much like your sister as a MoSiDa. I believe that the anomaly of the system's allowing joking with cousins, although it prohibits marriage, mitigates, in all probability, the force of the incest taboo and accounts to some extent for the tolerance towards the breakers of this rule.

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¹ Marshall, op. cit., pp. 13–15, 22–23.

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